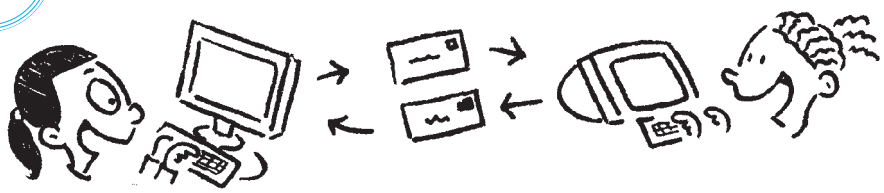
Read Words in Context

READ!



Serena: I've been to the school office three times today to find out if I passed the audition for the talent show. I kept asking if there was something I could do just so I could stay around. Mrs. Long said, "Go **badger someone** else. I'm busy." Sometimes I can **be an eager beaver** and show too much enthusiasm. —Charlene

Charlene: What's going on? Are you preparing an animal act? Have you trained a badger and a beaver to jump through hoops or something? —Serena

Serena: **Not by a long shot**! I'm using idioms! I thought what I was doing would be **as plain as the nose on your face**. After all, you know how much I love baton twirling. —Charlene

Charlene: Now I think that you are not being polite. I have a fine nose. And why are you speaking about my nose if you mean baton twirling? —Serena

Serena: You are **barking up the wrong tree** so let's start all over again. I performed a baton-twirling routine for the talent-show try-outs. It's a difficult routine, since I tap dance as I twirl. At one point, I was so tired I had to stop to **get a second wind**. I hope my stopping doesn't count against me and become **a fly in the ointment**. —Charlene

Charlene: I understand that the routine made you tired. Is that why you had to use an ointment—to sooth your aching muscles? I have heard of putting fruit or herbs in ointment but never flies! As your friend, I tell you that you need to calm down. You should not run around barking at trees like a dog. —Serena

Serena: I just got the results. Mr. Bryce thought I should be in the show, but Ms. Aaron thought I shouldn't. Finally, Mr. Bryce **got the upper hand** and I'm in. He said that Ms. Aaron didn't **have a leg to stand on**. There is no rule against pausing. I'm going to stop writing so that I can go to sleep and **catch forty winks** before the first rehearsal. —Charlene

Vocabulary Words

a fly in the ointment
a leg to stand on
as plain as the nose on your face
badger someone
bark up the wrong tree
be an eager beaver
catch forty winks
get a second wind
get the upper hand
not by a long shot

Word Learning Tip!

An idiom is a common expression that means something different from what the individual words normally mean. When these words are put together, they are an imaginative way of expressing a single idea. For example, the idiom "to catch someone's eye" doesn't mean that you go out and grab a person's eye! Instead, this idiom means that you got someone's attention.

Vocabulary Building Strategy

When several words in a row don't make sense, you could be reading an idiom. To determine the meaning of an idiom, think about the overall picture that the words could communicate.

Powerful Vocabulary for Reading Success: Grade 5 © Scholastic Teaching Resources

Connect Words and Meanings

a fly in the ointment	badger someone	get a second wind
a leg to stand on	bark up the wrong tree	get the upper hand
as plain as the nose on your face	be an eager beaver	not by a long shot
	catch forty winks	

Directions Read each idiom in the left-hand column. Match it with its definition in the right-hand column.

Idiom	Meaning
_____ **1.** be an eager beaver	**A.** something or someone that upsets a situation or causes a problem
_____ **2.** get a second wind	**B.** search for clues or answers in the wrong place
_____ **3.** a fly in the ointment	**C.** have a lot of enthusiasm; be too enthusiastic
_____ **4.** bark up the wrong tree	**D.** take a short nap
_____ **5.** as plain as the nose on your face	**E.** easy to see
_____ **6.** get the upper hand	**F.** not at all; definitely not
_____ **7.** not by a long shot	**G.** get enough energy to become active again
_____ **8.** a leg to stand on	**H.** get in a position that makes you superior to someone else; get the advantage
_____ **9.** badger someone	**I.** a supportable position
_____ **10.** catch forty winks	**J.** pester or bother someone







Idioms About Legs The idiom "to give a leg up" means to help someone. This very old idiom comes from riding horses. Originally, it meant to help someone get into the saddle. A lot of interesting and useful idioms use the word *leg*. Find the meaning of one of these "leg" idioms: *pulling your leg, to have good sea legs, to shake a leg, to stand on your own legs*. Then write a sentence using it.

Powerful Vocabulary for Reading Success: Grade 5 © Scholastic Teaching Resources

Use Words in Context

a fly in the ointment	**badger someone**	**get a second wind**
a leg to stand on	**bark up the wrong tree**	**get the upper hand**
as plain as the nose on your face	**be an eager beaver**	**not by a long shot**
	catch forty winks	

Directions Each of the following sentences has a vocabulary idiom in boldface. Answer each question. Write your answers in full sentences.

1. Why do you need to **get a second wind** when you are rehearsing late for a talent show?

2. If you were trying out for a talent show or other competition, what fact would you want to be **as plain as the nose on your face** for the judges?

3. How could you **get the upper hand** when you are working on a committee?

4. After what activities do you need to **catch forty winks**?

5. How can you stop an audience member who likes to **badger someone** who is performing?

6. What happens when you **bark up the wrong tree**?

7. What is something **an eager beaver** might do in a drama club?

8. If you ask the judge if you have a chance of winning and she replies, "**Not by a long shot**," are you happy or sad?

9. If there is **a fly in the ointment**, will you have an easy time accomplishing your goals or a hard time?

10. If you don't have **a leg to stand on** in an argument, are you likely to win or lose?

Learn More "Nose" Idioms The word *nose* appears in several idioms. For example, *have a nose for something* means "have a talent for something." Think about how police dogs find things. Then tell how you think this idiom may have come about.

Powerful Vocabulary for Reading Success: Grade 5 © Scholastic Teaching Resources

Put Words Into Action

a fly in the ointment	badger someone	get a second wind
a leg to stand on	bark up the wrong tree	get the upper hand
as plain as the nose on your face	be an eager beaver	not by a long shot
	catch forty winks	

Directions Use an idiom to complete each item below. Write it on the line. You may have to change the verb form or the pronoun in the idiom to make it fit.

1. If a detective keeps questioning the wrong suspect, he is _____.
2. If you are exhausted and need to restore your energy before starting again, you need to _____.
3. If you don't have any evidence to back up your opinions, you don't have _____.
4. If something is very obvious to you, it is _____.
5. If something disrupts your plans and might ruin your chances of winning, it is _____.
6. If you need to take a short nap before going to a party, you need to _____.
7. If you try to get in a position where someone will do exactly what you say, you want to _____.
8. If you show a lot of enthusiasm, you might _____.
9. If you ask too many questions and pester someone, you _____.
10. If you have absolutely no chance of getting on a team, the coach might say _____.

Find Other Idioms If you get the *upper hand*, you have an advantage. Working with a partner, write the word *advantage* in the center of a word web. Try to identify at least three other idioms that tell about having the advantage. For example, you might write *ahead of the game*.

Powerful Vocabulary for Reading Success: Grade 5 © Scholastic Teaching Resources

Review and Extend

a fly in the ointment	**badger someone**	**get a second wind**
a leg to stand on	**bark up the wrong tree**	**get the upper hand**
as plain as the nose on your face	**be an eager beaver**	**not by a long shot**
	catch forty winks	

Bonus Idioms Below are two more idioms and their meanings. Remember, you can't take the words at their face value in an idiom. The expression has an imaginative, rather than a literal meaning.

Idiom	Meaning
break new ground	start a new project, be different
pull the wool over your eyes	trick someone

Directions Read each item below. Choose the idiom that best fits the context. Write the idiom in the blank. You may have to change the verb form or the pronoun to make it fit the sentence.

1. The judge said to the sly lawyer, "Don't try your tricks with me. I won't let you _____."
2. Janice was tired from practicing her singing so she decided to _____.
3. She knew that a brief nap would help her _____.
4. Rico's talent was obvious to everyone. It was _____.
5. He was planning to _____ with his skit. It would be something completely different.
6. His plans weren't working as he expected. There was _____; the spotlight was broken.
7. He went to _____ on the stage crew to get them to fix the spotlight.
8. He did not have time to waste, so he could not _____. He had to find the right people to talk to because the show was almost ready to start.

Learn Animal Idioms The idioms "badger someone" and "be an eager beaver" refer to animals. Here are some more idioms that use animals: *raining cats and dogs, a dog-eat-dog world, a wolf in sheep's clothing, you can't teach an old dog new tricks, have a whale of a time, dog tired, a bee in your bonnet, crocodile tears.* Make a children's book using some or all of these idioms.

Powerful Vocabulary for Reading Success: Grade 5 © Scholastic Teaching Resources

Check Your Mastery

Directions Circle the letter of the correct answer to each question below.

1. If you **catch forty winks**, what are you doing?
A. taking a nap **B.** eating **C.** singing **D.** studying

2. Which of the following situations could be described as **a fly in the ointment**?
A. getting a good test grade
B. a train being on time
C. having a power failure during rush hour
D. getting a good night's sleep

3. If you **badger someone**, which word would that person most likely use to describe you?
A. helpful **B.** smart **C.** friendly **D.** annoying

4. When are you most likely to **get a second wind**?
A. when a race starts
B. when you are sleeping
C. after the race is over
D. during the second part of a race

5. In which situation would your parent be likely to tell you, "**Not by a long shot**!"
A. You want to take up a dangerous sport.
B. You want to help out in the kitchen.
C. You want to do your homework.
D. You want to brush your teeth.

6. Which of the following is most likely to be **as plain as the nose on your face**?
A. a fact you know well
B. being unsure what the future will bring
C. not knowing who will win an election
D. the solution to a difficult mystery

7. What happens if you **bark up the wrong tree**?
A. you find the answer
B. you win a contest
C. you look in the wrong place
D. you get bitten by a dog

8. Who would most likely **be an eager beaver**?
A. a lazy person **B.** a funny person **C.** a bored person **D.** a hard-working person

9. If you don't have **a leg to stand on**, you are probably
A. losing the argument
B. correct
C. winning the argument
D. hurt

10. To **get the upper hand** in a debate so you have an advantage, what should you do?
A. be prepared
B. catch forty winks during it
C. badger someone
D. bark up the wrong tree

Powerful Vocabulary for Reading Success: Grade 5 © Scholastic Teaching Resources